



COBIT 5® Foundation Examination Syllabus

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1 Introduction

The COBIT 5 'Business Framework for the Governance and Management of Enterprise IT' introduces the candidate to the five basic principles which are covered in detail and includes extensive guidance on enablers for governance and management of enterprise IT. Also included are the foundation concepts of a process assessment model (PAM) based on the ISO 15504 approach which replaces the previous CMM (Capability Maturity Model). This is an expansion of Chapter 8 of the guide and reflects key pieces of foundation knowledge that has been taken from the COBIT Process Assessment Model (PAM) using COBIT 5. Extracts from the Enabling process guide are also being tested; however whilst we encourage ATO's to use this guide in their training material, the purpose of this guide is as a reference guide for the revised COBIT 5 processes and it is not possible to test much of this as most of the examinable concepts are in the framework and have already been included in the syllabus..

The primary purpose of the syllabus is to provide a basis for accreditation of the COBIT 5 Foundation Level certificate. It documents the learning outcomes related to the use of COBIT and describes the requirements a candidate is expected to meet to demonstrate that these learning outcomes have been achieved at the Foundation level.

The target audience for this document is:

- Exam Board
- Exam Panel
- APMG Assessment Team
- Accredited Training Organizations.

This syllabus informs the design of the exam and provides accredited training organizations with a more detailed breakdown of what the exam will assess. Details on the exam structure and content are documented in the COBIT 5 Foundation Design.

2 Foundation Certificate

2.1 Purpose of the COBIT 5 Foundation Certificate

The purpose of the Foundation certificate is to confirm that a candidate has sufficient knowledge and understanding of the COBIT 5 guidance to be able to understand the enterprise Governance and Management of Enterprise IT, create awareness with their business executives and senior IT Management; assess the current state of their Enterprise IT with the objective of scoping what aspects of COBIT 5 would be appropriate to implement. **The Foundation level training and certificate** is also a pre-requisite for the following training and certificate courses:

- COBIT 5 Implementation Training & certificate
- COBIT 5 Assessor Training & certificate

2.2 Target Audience for the COBIT 5 Foundation Level training and Certificate

Business Management, Chief Executives, IT /IS Auditors, Internal Auditors, Information Security and IT Practitioners; Consultants, IT/IS Management looking to gain an insight into the Enterprise Governance of IT and looking to be certified as a COBIT Implementer or Assessor.

2.3 High Level Performance Definition of a Successful Foundation Candidate

The candidate should understand the key principles and terminology within COBIT 5. Specifically the candidate should **know and understand**:

-
- The COBIT 5 Product Architecture.
- The IT management issues and challenges that affect enterprises.
- The 5 Key Principles of COBIT 5 for the governance and management of Enterprise IT.
- How COBIT 5 enables IT to be governed and managed in a holistic manner for the entire enterprise.

- How the COBIT 5 processes and the Process Reference Model (PRM) help guide the creation of the 5 Principles and the 7 Governance and Management Enablers.
- The basic concepts for the Implementation of COBIT 5.
- The components and purpose of the Process Reference Guide
- The basic concepts of a RACI and how they are used in COBIT 5.
- The basic concepts of the new Process Assessment Model.
- The COBIT 5 guides and how they interrelate.

3 Learning Outcomes Assessment Model

A classification widely used when designing assessments for certification and education is the Bloom's Taxonomy of Educational Objectives. This classifies learning objectives into six ascending learning levels, each defining a higher degree of competencies and skills (Bloom et al, 1956, Taxonomy of Educational Objectives).

APMG have incorporated this into a Learning Outcomes Assessment Model which is used to provide a simple and systematic means for assessing and classifying the learning outcomes for APMG qualifications.

This structured approach helps to ensure:

- A clear delineation in learning level content between different qualification levels
- Learning outcomes are documented consistently across different areas of the guidance
- Exam questions and papers are consistent and are created to a similar level of difficulty.

The Foundation certificate examines learning outcomes at levels 1 (knowledge) and 2 (comprehension).

	1.Knowledge	2. Comprehension
Generic Definition from APMG Learning Outcomes Assessment Model	Know key facts, terms and concepts from the manual/guidance	Understand key concepts from the manual/guidance
COBIT 5 Learning Outcome Assessment Model	To Know the facts, terms, concepts, and principles, including tools, techniques, roles and responsibilities from the COBIT 5 Framework Guidance and the COBIT Process Assessment Model (PAM).	Understand the concepts, principles, processes, features, organizational factors and roles and can explain how these are applied to justify, design and implement the COBIT 5 framework and the COBIT Process Assessment model (PAM)

4 Syllabus Areas

The syllabus is presented by syllabus areas. This is the unit of learning which may relate to a chapter from the manual/guidance or several concepts commonly grouped together in a training course module.

The following syllabus areas are identified.

Syllabus Area Code	Syllabus Area Title
PR	The COBIT 5 Principles
EN	The COBIT 5 Enablers
IM	Introduction to COBIT 5 Implementation
PC	Process Capability Assessment Model

5 Syllabus Presentation

For each syllabus area learning outcomes for each learning level are identified. Each learning outcome is then supported by a description of the requirements that a candidate is expected to meet to demonstrate that the learning outcome has been achieved at the qualification level indicated. These are shown as syllabus topics.

All Foundation level requirements must be met before a candidate can move onto the Implementation and Assessor training and certificate programme. Foundation level knowledge and understanding will not be repeated in more advanced courses but can be used when demonstrating application and analysis learning outcomes.

Each of the syllabus areas is presented in a similar format as follows:

Syllabus Area Code **PG [2]**		**Syllabus Area :** ***QUAL Syllabus Area* (XX) Theme** [1]	**Foundation**	**Practitioner**	**Primary References**
Level	Topic				
Know facts, terms and concepts relating to the *syllabus area*. [3] **Specifically to recall:**					
01 [4]	01 [5]	[6]	[7]		[8]
01	02				

Key to the Syllabus Area table

1	Syllabus Area	Unit of learning, e.g. chapter of the reference guide or course module.
2	Syllabus Area Code	A unique 2 character code identifying the syllabus area.
3	Learning Outcome (topic header shown in bold)	A statement of what a candidate will be expected to know, understand or do.
4	Level	Classification of the learning outcome against the APMG OTE Learning Outcomes Assessment Model.

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5	Topic Reference	Number of the topic within the learning level.
6	Topic Description	Description of what is required of the candidate to demonstrate that a learning outcome has been achieved at the qualification level indicated
7	Foundation/Practitioner	Shows at which qualification level the topic is assessed. N.B A topic is only assessed at one qualification level.
8	Primary Reference	The main reference supporting the topic.

6 Important Points

The following points about the use of the syllabus should be noted.

COBIT 5 Guide References

The COBIT 5 guide references provided should be considered to be indicative rather than comprehensive, i.e. there may be other valid references within the guidance. The main reference guides for the COBIT 5 Foundation certificate are:

- COBIT 5 - 'A Business Framework for the Governance and Management of Enterprise IT'. Most references to chapters, figures and appendices shown in the reference column below are sourced from this guide and
- The 'COBIT Process Assessment Model (PAM) – using COBIT 5'.
- Extracts from the Enabling Process Guide.

7 Syllabus Exclusions

None

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Syllabus Area Code PR		Syllabus Area: The COBIT 5 Principles		
Know facts and terms relating to the five Principles of COBIT 5. Specifically to recall:				
01	01	**The names and Key aspects of the five key Principles** for governance and management of enterprise IT • Principle 1 – Meeting Stakeholder Needs • Principle 2 – Covering the Enterprise End-to-End • Principle 3 – Applying a Single Integrated Framework • Principle 4 – Enabling a Holistic Approach • Principle 5 – Separating Governance from Management	✓	Figure 2 Principles model page 13 executive summary
01	02	**The names and descriptions of the seven categories of Enablers** that influence how the governance and management of IT works: • Enabler 1 – Principles, Policies and Frameworks • Enabler 2 – Processes • Enabler 3 – Organisational Structures • Enabler 4 – Culture, Ethics and Behaviour • Enabler 5 – Information • Enabler 6 – Services, Infrastructure and Applications • Enabler 7 – People, Skills and Competencies.	✓	Figure 12 Chapter 5 Page 27 and appendix G
01	03	The Process Reference Model Governance Domain, specifically, the names of the five processes in the Governance Domain.	✓	Chapter 6 Figure 16 Governance/management interactions page 33
01	04	The process Reference Model Management Domain, specifically: 1. The names of the processes in APO (Align, Plan Organize) 2. The names of the processes in BAI (Build, Acquire and Implement) 3. The names of the processes in DSS (Deliver, Service and Support) 4. The names of the processes in MEA (Monitor, Evaluate and Assess)	✓	Chapter 6 Figure 16 Governance/management interactions page 33
01	05	The four questions to ask when establishing how to manage the enabler performance: • Are stakeholder needs addressed? • Are enabler goals achieved? • Is the enabler life cycle managed? • Are good practices applied?	✓	Chapter 5 page 28 to 29 Figure 13 The generic enabler model
Understand the concepts relating to the structure and format of the framework, the drivers and business benefits of using the COBIT 5 framework. Specifically to identify*:*				
Principle 1 – Meeting Stakeholder Needs			✓	Chapter 2 Pages 17 to 22 Figure 3
02	01	How the Governance Objective of Value Creation meets stakeholder needs using: • Benefits realisation • Risk optimisation • Resource optimisation	✓	Chapter 2 page 17 Figure 3
02	02	The types of Stakeholder drivers and where they fit into the COBIT 5 goals cascade mechanism.	✓	Chapter 2 pages 17 to 18 Figures 4

02	03	The importance of Stakeholder needs and where they fit in the COBIT 5 goals cascade mechanism, in particular: 1. The importance of transforming stakeholder needs into an enterprise's actionable strategy 2. How stakeholder needs cascade to enterprise goals 3. The relationship to the balance score card.	✓	Chapter 2 page 17 to 19 and Figure 5 appendix D page 55
02	04	The relationships of the enterprise goals to the 3 main governance objectives: 1. The (p) Primary and (S) secondary relationship to Benefits realisation 2. The (P) Primary and (S) secondary relationship to Risk Optimisation 3. The (P) Primary and (S) secondary relationship to Resource Optimisation.	✓	Chapter 2 page 17 to 19 and Figure 5
02	05	How Enterprise Goals cascade to IT-related Goals within the COBIT 5 goals cascade mechanism, specifically: • The relationship of IT-related goals to IT-related outcomes.	✓	Chapter 2 page 18 to 19 Figure 6 & Appendix C
02	06	How IT-related Goals cascade to Enabler Goals within the COBIT 5 goals cascade mechanism, specifically: 1. What is an enabler goal 2. How IT-related Goals support IT-related processes.	✓	Chapter 2 page 18 to 19 Appendix C
02	07	The purpose of the Goals Cascade mechanism.	✓	Chapter 2 Page 17 2nd paragraph
Principle 2 – Covering the Enterprise End-to-end			✓	Chapter 3 Pages 23 to 24
02	08	The key components of a Governance System	✓	Chapter 3 Figure 8 page 23
02	09	How Key roles and activities interrelate: 1. Role of the stakeholders and their activities, accountabilities and responsibilities 2. Role of the Governing Body and their responsibilities 3. Role of Management and their activities and responsibilities 4. The role of Operations and their activities and responsibilities	✓	Chapter 3 Figure 9 page 24 Page 31 Chapter 6
Principle 3 – Applying a single Integrated Framework.				
02	10	The purpose of the COBIT 5 Integrator model and how it integrates and aligns with existing ISACA guidance, new guidance and other standards and frameworks.	✓	Chapter 4 Figure 10 page 25
02	11	The reasons why COBIT 5 is an integrated Framework	✓	Chapter 4 Figure 10 Page 25
Principle 4 - Enabling a Holistic Approach				
02	12	The importance of the key components of the enabler dimension: 1. Stakeholder dimension 2. The Goals Dimension 3. The Life Cycle Dimension 4. The Good Practices dimension	✓	Chapter 5 page 28 to 29 Figure 13 The generic enabler model
02	13	The purpose of measurement indicators in the achievement of Goals. • Lag indicators • Lead indicators	✓	Chapter 5 page 29 Figure 13 The generic enabler model
Principle 5 – Separating Governance from Management				

02	14	The definition and responsibilities of Governance and Management	✓	Chapter 6 Figure 14 Governance/management interactions page 31
02	15	The interactions between governance and management	✓	Chapter 6 Figure 15 Governance/management interactions page 32

Syllabus Area Code: EN		**Syllabus Area: The COBIT 5 Enablers**		
Know facts and terms relating to the COBIT 5 Enablers. Specifically to recall:				
01	01	The definition of a Process.	✓	Appendix G page 69
Understand that COBIT enables IT to be governed and managed in a holistic manner for the entire enterprise. Specifically to identify:				
Enabler 1 - Principles, Policies and Frameworks				
02	01	The purpose of principles, policies and frameworks in the enabling model.	✓	Appendix G pages 67
02	02	The differences between Policies and Principles	✓	Appendix G page 67
02	03	The characteristics of good policies.	✓	Appendix G pages 67
02	04	The purpose of the Policy life cycle.	✓	Appendix G page 68
02	05	The **good practice** requirements for policies, principles and frameworks, specifically: • Their scope • Consequences of failing to comply with the policy • The means of handling exceptions • How they will be monitored.	✓	Appendix G Figure 28 pages67 & 68
02	06	The links and relationships between the Principles, policies and frameworks Enabler and other enablers, specifically: • Principles, policies and frameworks reflect the cultures, ethics and values of the enterprise • Processes are the most important vehicle for executing policies • Organisational structures can define and implement policies • Policies are part of information.	✓	Appendix G Figure 28 pages67 & 68
Enabler 2 - Processes				
02	07	Examples of Internal and External stakeholders	✓	Appendix G Figure 29 pages 69 to 74
02	08	The key characteristics of the process goal categories: 1. Intrinsic goals 2. Contextual goals 3. Accessibility & Security goals.	✓	Appendix G Figure 29 pages 69 to 74
02	09	The activities in the process life cycle.	✓	Appendix G page70
02	10	The differences in the Process Reference Model between Process Practices, Process Activities, Inputs and Outputs (Work products).	✓	Appendix G Figure 31 PRM and pages 70
02	11	The Relationships between the Processes enabler and other enablers, specifically: • Processes need information as one form of input • Processes need Organizational structure • Processes produce and require services, infrastructure and applications • Processes are dependent on other processes • Processes need policies and procedures to ensure consistent implementation.	✓	Appendix G page 71

Enabler 3 - Organizational Structures				
02	12	The Good Practices of an organizational structure, specifically: • Operating principles • Span of control • Level of authority • Delegation of responsibility • Escalation procedures • Decision making	✓	Appendix G Figure 32 pages 75 to 77
02	13	The responsibilities and characteristics of the following roles in an organization: • Board • CEO • CFO • COO • CRO • CIO • CISO • Business Executive • Business Process Owner • Strategy (IT Executive) Committee • (Project and Programme) Steering Committees • Architecture Board • Enterprise Risk Committee • Audit • Head of Architecture • Head of IT Operations • Head of IT Administration • Programme and Project Management Office (PMO) • Value Management Office (VMO) • Service Manager • Information Security Manager • Business Continuity Manager • Privacy Officer	✓	Appendix G Figure 33 pages 76 & 77
Enabler 4 - Culture, Ethics and Behaviour				
02	14	The good practices for creating, encouraging and maintaining desired behaviour throughout the enterprise.	✓	Appendix G Figure 34 pages 79 to 80
02	15	The relationship of Goals for culture, ethics and behaviour to: • Organisational ethics • Individual ethics • Individual behaviours	✓	Appendix G Figure 34 pages 79 to 80
02	16	The links and relationships of the Culture, ethics and behaviour enabler and to the other enablers, specifically: • Processes • Organizational structures • Principles, Policies and frameworks	✓	Appendix G Page 80
Enabler 5 - Information				
02	17	The importance of the information criteria and dimensions of the COBIT 5 Information enablers.	✓	Appendix F Page 63
02	18	The five steps of the Information Cycle, and how they interrelate and apply to the Information enablers	✓	Appendix G Page 81 Figure 35

02	19	The possible uses of the Information Model.	✓	Appendix G Page 84
Enabler 6 - Services, Infrastructure and Applications				
02	20	The five architecture principles that govern the implementation and use of IT-related resources.	✓	Appendix G Page 85 Figure 37
02	21	The relationship of the Services, Infrastructure and Applications Enabler to the other enablers, specifically: • Information • Culture, ethics and behaviour • Processes, specifically the inputs and outputs	✓	Appendix G Page 86
Enabler 7 - People, Skills and Competencies				
02	22	The good practices of skills and competencies, specifically: • Defining skill requirements for each role • Mapping skill categories to the COBIT 5 process domains (e.g. EDM, APO etc. • Using other external sources good practices	✓	Appendix G Page 87 Figure 38
02	23	The skill categories, related to the following COBIT Process Domains: • EDM (Evaluate, Direct and Monitor) • APO (Align, Organize and Plan) • BAI (Build, Acquire and Implement) • DSS (Deliver, Service and Support) • MEA (Monitor, Evaluate and Assess)	✓	Appendix G Page 88 Figure 39
Enabler Process Guide Content				
02	24	The components and purpose of the Process Reference Guide including:- • Process identification and its components • Process description • Process purpose statement • Goals cascade information • Process goals and metrics Overview of process practices	✓	EN Guide Chapter 5 page 25
02	25	The components and purpose of the Process Reference Guide including:- • Roles within a RACI chart and their differences	✓	EN Guide Chapter 5 page 25

Syllabus Area Code: IM		Syllabus Area: An Introduction to COBIT 5 Implementation		
To know facts, terms and concepts relating to the Implementation of COBIT 5, specifically to recall:				
01	01	The three interrelated components of the life cycle model. • Management of the programme • Change enablement specifically addressing behaviour and cultural aspects and • Core continual improvement life cycle.	✓	Chapter 7 Figure 17 Pages 37 & 38
Understand the guidance that ISACA offers on implementing COBIT 5, the use of the continual improvement life cycle' in enabling change in an enterprise. Specifically to identify:				
02	01	The enterprise specific **internal and external environment** factors as they apply to change management: • Ethics and culture • Applicable laws, regulations and policies • Mission, vision and values • Governance policies and practices • Business plans and strategic intentions • Operating Model • Management style • Risk appetite • Capabilities and available resources • Industry practices	✓	Chapter 7 Page 35 & 36
02	02	The Importance of **Pain Points and Trigger events** that require improved governance and management of enterprise IT, specifically: • Typical pain points: o Business frustration with failed IT initiatives resulting in increased costs & low business return on investment o Outsourcing service delivery problems o Duplicate projects o Continuous poor audit findings o Board members and senior management reluctant to engage with IT • Typical Trigger Events: o Mergers, acquisitions and divestments o New regulatory or compliance requirements o A shift in the market demand for the company's products o Significant technology change	✓	Chapter 7 Page 36 & 37
02	03	The importance of the business case to a programme initiative leveraging COBIT 5.	✓	Chapter 7 Page 38

02	04	The characteristics of a good business case and what it should typically include, specifically**:** • The business benefits that will be realized • The business changes required • The investments needed • The on-going IT operating costs • Constraints and dependencies derived from the risk assessment • Roles, responsibilities and accountabilities relative to other initiative • How the investment will be monitored	✓	Chapter 7 Page 38 & 39
02	05	The purpose of each of the three interrelated components of the life cycle.	✓	Chapter 7 page 37
02	06	The relationship between the three rings of the implementation life cycle for phases 1, 2 and 3: • What are the drivers? • Where are we now? And • Where do we want to be?	✓	Chapter 7 page 37 & 38
02	07	The relationship between the three rings of the implementation life cycle for phases 4, 5, 6 & 7: • What needs to be done? • How do we get there? • Did we get there? And • How do we keep the momentum going?	✓	Chapter 7 page 37 & 38

Syllabus Area Code: PC		Syllabus Area: Process Capability Model (The Process Assessment Model) {PAM}		Chapter 8
To know facts, terms and concepts relating to the Process Capability Model. Specifically to recall:				
01	01	The six Capability Levels based on ISO 15504: • Level 0 – Incomplete Process • Level 1 – Performed process • Level 2 – Managed process • Level 3 - Established Process • Level 4 - Predictable Process • Level 5 – Optimised Process	✓	COBIT 5 Chapter 8 Figure 19 page 42
01	02	The nine Attributes based on ISO 15504: • PA 1.1 Process performance • PA 2.1 Performance management • PA 2.2 Work product management • PA 3.1 Process definition • PA 3.2 Process deployment • PA 4.1 Process measurement • PA 4.2 Process control • PA 5.1 Process innovation • PA 5.2 Process optimisation	✓	Chapter 8 Figure 19 page 42
01	03	The Rating Scale based on ISO 15504: • N Not achieved 0 to 15% achievement - There is little or no evidence of achievement of the defined attribute in the assessed process. • P Partially achieved 15% to 50% achievement - There is evidence of a sound systematic approach to an achievement of the defined attribute in the assessment approach • L Largely achieved 50% to 85% achievement - There is evidence of a sound, systematic approach to the significant achievement of the defined attribute in the assessment • F Fully achieved 85% to 100% achievement - There is evidence of a complete and systematic approach to and full achievement of the defined attribute in the assessed approach.	✓	Chapter 8 page 45 & PAM 2.5
01	04	The definition of the following ISO 15504 terms: 1. A Process Purpose 2. A Process Outcome 3. A Base Practice 4. A Work Product	✓	COBIT 5 PAM 1.7
To understand the Process Capability Model and the basic ISO 15504 concepts. Specifically to identify:				
02	01	The Purposes of carrying out a Process Capability Assessment, specifically to recognise the following objectives • Enable management to benchmark process capability • Enable high-level 'as is' and 'to be' health checks • To provide gap analysis and improvement planning information • To provide management with assessment ratings to measure and monitor current capabilities •	✓	COBIT 5 Chapter 8 page 45

02	02	The Scope of the COBIT assessment programme, specifically the purpose of the 3 guides: 1. The Process Assessment Model (PAM) using COBIT 4.1 and COBIT 5 2. The Assessor Guide – using COBIT 5 and COBIT 4.1 3. The Self-Assessment Guide – using COBIT 4.1 and COBIT 5	✓	COBIT 5 PAM 1.5 pages 7 and 8.
02	03	The purpose of a Process Reference Model in the PAM.	✓	COBIT 5 PAM Chapter 1.7 Appendix 2.4
02	04	The Assessment Indicators and the differences between the two dimensions outlined in the ISO 15504 approach: • The Process capability attribute indicators which apply to levels 1 to 5 and • The Process performance indicators (base Practices and work products) which are specific for each process and are used to determine whether a process is at capability level 1.	✓	COBIT 5 PAM 2.4
		1.		
02	05	The benefits of the COBIT Capability Assessment approach.	✓	COBIT 5 Chapter 8 page 44
02	06	How the rating scales are used in an assessment • To achieve a pass for a certain level, a process must be rated L – Largely or F – Fully at that level, and be rated F-Fully on the lower levels. • To be able to move onto another capability level all Process Attributes must be F – fully for that process (if not achieved, the organisation needs to improve that particular process attribute to have a F rating before moving on)	✓	Chapter 8 Page 45 & COBIT 5 PAM 2.5